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Expanding the Ocean of Opportunities

It's time to boost coastal shipping, expand navigable waterways and leverage India's strategic location to strengthen maritime trade

By KAUSHIK DEKA

The ports, shipping and waterways ministry plays a crucial role in strengthening the country's domestic and external trade and commerce. Nearly 95 per cent of India's overseas trade by volume is carried out via its ports. Yet, the country accounts for just over 10 per cent of the global deadweight tonnage. The government has been trying to make amends through the flagship Sagar Mala programme, harnessing India's 7,500 km coastline, 14,500 km of potentially navigable waterways and strategic location on key international maritime trade routes. The results are showing—India's rank in international shipment category has jumped from 44 in 2014 to 22 now. The importance of the ministry can be gauged from the fact that on May 13, in the middle of the seven-phase Lok Sabha polls, minister Sarbananda Sonowal visited Iran's Chabahar port to witness the signing ceremony of the Long-term Main Contract for its development—an India-Iran flagship project. Amid the ongoing wars in Ukraine and West Asia, this project will serve as a trade route connecting India with Afghanistan and the Central Asian countries. ■

SARBANANDA SONOWAL, *61* | BJP

Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways

↘ **A legal base** Born in Assam's Dibrugarh district, Sonowal is armed with degrees in law and mass communication

↘ **Long-haul man** He fought a lone legal battle against Assam's Illegal Migrants (Determination by Tribunals) Act, 1983, and became its poster boy as 'Jatiya Nayak' (Assam's hero). He was the first BJP CM in the state. That he has retained his portfolio since 2021 reflects the PM's faith in his work

↘ **Yoga buff** A former bodybuilder and cricketer, the bachelor minister practises yoga every day

Minister of State



SHANTANU THAKUR, *41* | BJP

↘ **Community power** Son of former Bengal minister Manjul Krishna Thakur, he belongs to the politically powerful Matua SC community. He was inducted into the Modi Cabinet first in 2021 and continues in the same portfolio. In 2019, he became the first non-TMC leader to be elected from Bangaon

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

INFRA UPGRADE While the average container dwell time and turnaround time of Indian ports are better than several developed countries such as the US, Australia, Singapore and Germany, the existing port infrastructure needs a faster upgrade

BUILD LOCALLY The local shipbuilding ecosystem needs to be fast-tracked to replace the old merchant fleet

INLAND WATERWAYS More focus is needed on inland waterways to supplement the overburdened railways and congested roads

GREEN INITIATIVES The usage of alternative fuel technologies for vessels, as envisaged by the Green Port Guidelines, 2023, should be a priority to meet the zero carbon emission goal